Chapter 3: The Lost City of Raya



Ruins of a civilization long forgotten dot the landscape, their stone walls whispering names of gods no longer worshipped. Raya lies in a basin hidden in the depths of the rainforest, surrounded on all sides by sheer cliffs. The city is notoriously difficult to find. Those who try must contend with miles of trackless jungle, inhabited by natural predators and the remnants of Ras Nsi's undead army.

Once a jewel in Kroonstad's crown, Raya was built over rich mineral veins. It garnered wealth in abundance, to the point that Rayan jewelry was coveted far and wide. To enter Raya, it was said, was to enter the gates of paradise itself.

With Ubtao's death, Raya's clerics lost their spells, and the city fell to sickness and diseases. As Raya sought new divinities, primal spirits - guided by Saleander - arose from the rainforest disguised as jungle creatures. They promised hope, in return for devotion. Desperate for redemption, the Rayans tore down their temples to Ubtao and raised shrines to the Owsla.

After a century and a half of peace, the trickster spirits sought, against the wishes of their goddess, to expand their flock. Driven by a desire to take over Mezro, the other holy city, Raya's legions marched across the continent, leaving behind a devastating wake of genocide now known as the War of Axe and Vine.

Despite their decisive victory, not much is known about Raya's collapse. All that remains are the ruins of a glorious civilisation. In the current day - almost five centuries later - kobolds, grungs, and yuan-ti have established a post apocalyptic society amidst the destruction. The 52nd Expedition, driven by a desire to rescue the soul of Vilde's mother the Senator Arianwen Amadeus, race to Raya. As time runs out, fault lines begin to appear amongst the Party. Can they trust each other and work together to achieve the mission, or will they fall victim to doubt and suspicion?

Race to Raya

Resupplied with the best Camp Vengeance had to offer, Mason ensured sufficient food and water for the Party. The Expedition, now accompanied by Vilde's half-sister Ariadne, race towards Raya.

Electing to retrace their steps, the Party bolts across the Aldani Basin. Despite taking a path they have treaded before, the road is fraught with peril. The 52nd Expedition continue to encounter hordes of zombies, yuan-ti patrols, and dinosaurs, which they resoundly defeat. Aside from enemies, the Party finds several interesting sites: several failed Expedition sites, remnants of Red Wizard activity, and even a *Webway* portal.

The Final Stretch

The Party will no longer need to make foraging checks. They will only need to make Wisdom (Survival) checks for navigation purposes. The other Players can either give Intelligence (Investigation) checks to investigate some of the locations they find and learn more about Raya on approach, or Wisdom (Perception) checks to obtain loot.

The Party will travel at a fast pace. There is a 50/50 chance that they will be able to move one additional hex per day.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a successful **DC 10** check, the Expedition finds a *Potion of Healing* and 100 copper pieces.

On a successful **DC 15** check, the Expedition finds a *Potion of Healing (Greater)* and 1d10 x 100 silver pieces.

On a successful **DC 20** check, the Expedition finds a *Potion of Fire Resistance* and 2d10 x 10 gold pieces.

On a successful **DC 25** check, the Expedition finds a *Potion of Frost Giant Strength* and 1d10 x 10 platinum pieces.

As the 52nd Expedition takes down zombie horde after zombie horde, they recognize that they all have an upside-down blue triangle painted on their heads, which they recognize as a mark of Ras Nsi.

They also find corpses of Red Wizards, littered throughout the jungle. Whilst powerful undead spellcasters, many of them seem to have succumbed to starvation. Salazar, Raphael and Hazel can all intuit that the Devourer's monopoly on souls planetwide has caused many liches to weaken as they do not have a steady supply of souls for their own phylacteries. They also find correspondence on the corpse of one of the Red Wizards signed by Elizabeth Shadowmantle, explaining that they have "identified Raya as the home of the Devourer," and that they have "seized a compound as their base of operations." The lich also calls for all Red Wizards to gather at the compound, as "the Tomb of Annihilation would require all hands on deck." They also find Raya's true location from the letter, allowing them to pinpoint the location of the lost city.

Four days after their visit to Camp Vengeance, the Party arrives at Tamoachan. Hazel pushes the Party to investigate the shrine.

> Finding an easily defended glade with an artesian spring, you settle to make camp as some of you peel off to investigate the shrine. You see that much of the shrine is toppled and completely covered in undergrowth. A ziggurat rising out of the dense foliage, the pyramid temple stands eerily silent across cracked and overgrown flagstones.

Ariadne and Thaisha comb the area, and find that almost all of the entrances to the shrine has been sealed off, both magically and naturally. They, however, chance upon a Webway portal built into the shrine's entrance.



Hazel finds the only viable entrance into Tamoachan: a dark maw deep into the earth in a clearing near the pyramid temple. Through it, the cleric sees a pale green gas swirling in the depths.

"We should go," Thaisha says as the Party reconvenes around Hazel. "The ruin will still be here when we get back."

Nodding, Hazel drops a stone into the maw. She sees it disappear into the darkness, and intuits that it must be a forty foot drop. Deciding to come back here on their return journey, the Party pushes on.

As the Party closes in on Raya, they find more and more abandoned Expedition campsites.

As you get closer and closer to Raya, five days after setting off from Camp Vengeance, you find a mysterious, abandoned campsite. Torn backpacks and rotted gear litter the ground around three moldering tents. Unlike the others, at the center of the camp, a scrap of dirty yellow cloth hangs from a crude wooden flagpole.

Tearing this place apart, you find a mouldy journal in one of the tents.

Intelligence (History) Check
On a successful **DC 15** check, Wang Lei does not recognize the flag.

Reading the journal, the Party sees that the 33rd Expedition did not only want to destroy the Devourer, but also wanted to find the *Eye of Zaltec*. They have also learnt that the entrance to the Tomb of Annihilation is the black obelisk in the north of the city, and that "you need all nine puzzle cubes to open the Tomb."

They also find the campsites for the 17th, 26th, and 47th Expeditions. While some of the campsites tell the stories of how their predecessors met their end, usually in a gruesome battle, others are more mysterious. Salazar pieces together the research from all of these campsites, trying to identify where in the city are the nine shrines.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a successful DC **25** check, Salazar learns the unifying architectural trait of all the nine shrines, built in worship to the angels that serve Saleander. Recognizing that these can be used to identify the buildings when they are in Raya, he shares with the group that a distinctive feature of the nine shrines is that there are Celestial inscriptions at the top of the shrine that describes the trickster spirit it is dedicated to.

After Salazar shares his findings, Hazel and Ariadne updates the group that you are perhaps half a day's journey away.

That very night, as you all settle into camp, Vilde heads off to start cooking. As she does, Wang Lei you and Mason begin training. As you spar, you swing your mace with a vicious backhand as he tries to parry it with his javelin.

Strength (Athletics) Check
On a successful contested check, Wang Lei knocks Mason onto the ground.

With a mighty swing, you smash the mace into Mason's helmet, knocking him back. The squire stumbles and falls to the ground. Frustrated, you see Mason takes off his helm and throws it away. He takes out his waterskin and chugs a swig of water to cool off, before passing it over to you.

The knight takes a swig as well, hydrating. "Now, now. This is part of the journey. You will do better next time. Keep trying."

"Sir Wang Lei, if you wouldn't mind," Mason says abruptly. "A personal question."

"Yeah, sure," the knight says. He joins him on the ground.

"I know you are a man of few words, so I will get straight to the point," Mason continues. "I'm sure it has not escaped your assessment that I have much to work on. The assassination... the Senator's death is a huge wake up call. I wasn't there for the Lady Vilde, when I should be. I am afraid that I am not strong enough."

"I feel the same," Wang Lei says. "But I haven't given up. And so you shouldn't either."

"Wait, what? Do you, really? You're one of the strongest people I know," The squire asks, incredulous.

"It takes time," Wang Lei says. "Be patient. If you keep at it, you'll be able to be much stronger."

He nods. "I see, sir." The squire pauses, as if hesitating so that he can try and find the right words.

"Something on your mind?" Wang Lei prods.

"I fear that not all in our Party have the best interests for my Lady. There are many that seek to invade her privacy, and learn her secrets. What do you think we should do with them?"

"The main objective is not Vilde," Wang Lei says matter-of-factly. "The objective is to destroy the Devourer."

Rubbing his head, still sore from the force of the mace, Mason continues, "And what if those seeking her secrets are a lycanthrope and has actively hurt two people of this Expedition, bringing them close to death?" Mason presses. A dark look passes over his face. "He almost killed me. When do we say 'enough is enough' and strike at them?"

"That is a problem we have to resolve later," Wang Lei says. "The Devourer comes first - "

"But we're not going to be able to destroy the Devourer with him," Mason points out. "There's a real possibility that he just hulks out during the battle and hurts one of us. He will be detrimental to the mission."

Wang Lei pauses, thinking. "We just have to be strategic. It can work to our advantage," the knight explains.

"I don't know," Mason says, dejected. "He almost killed me. He almost killed Lady Vilde. He almost killed Salazar, during the assassination, from what I heard."

"It's okay," Wang Lei says. "Just keep your distance. We have seen that he attacks the nearest individual; doesn't matter if it is friend or foe. If we stay away, we might be able to harness this force."

Charisma (Persuasion) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Wang Lei convinces Mason to stand down.

"Don't try anything stupid, please," Wang Lei continues. "We will deal with it later. Look, we know that he has specific triggers, which we can avoid. I believe the risk is worth the benefit. Wukong is a valued member of the Expedition, and his presence and actions on the field of battle is inspiring, enough to shake people out of shellshock at times. We should help him to work through the curse, instead of just banishing or killing him."

Mason nods. The squire remains silent for a long time as he contemplates the knight's words. "I see what you are saying, sir," Mason finally says. "Maybe I should have used *Blackrazor,*" he says. "Then I would have been strong enough."

"No, no, no," Wang Lei replies. "There's much for you to work on, not just physical traits, but mental as well." Wang Lei stands up, putting on his helmet again. "And besides, *Blackrazor* would rip you apart. Now, come," the knight orders. "We must continue training."

Mason nods, collecting his helmet. The fighters continue their training.

As the smell of Vilde's delicious cooking wafts around the camp, where do we find Hazel?

Wanting to protect her pristine duck confit and medium rare steak from the dangers of Hazel's cooking, Vilde casts *Druidcraft* to create a plant-based set of cooking utensils for the cleric. Hazel, not recognizing the illusion, happily helps the rogue cook dinner.


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As the pair cooks, Thaisha's head pops in the kitchen door. "Hi guys, can I borrow Hazel for a bit?"

"Sure," Vilde says, smirking. "She's busy over there."

Hazel wipes her paws on her apron, removing it carefully and setting it on a hook. "What's up?"

"I wanted to talk about what you and Wukong saw, back at Camp Vengeance," Thaisha says. "Do you... know what I'm talking about?"

"You and your - "

"Um, yes, that's the one," Thaisha interjects. "I... had a conversation with Hal. Now that I've renounced Saleander, he shared that he is willing to try and rebuild what we had."

"They don't have to be separate things, you know," the rabbitfolk says. "Have you considered a low-commitment relationship to Saleander?"

"What does that look like?" The druid asks.

"An hour of prayer a week," Hazel offers. "You don't have to fully worship her, just... you know, do it to keep touch."

"I mean... I don't know," Thaisha shares. "You see, he just bought a theater, so maybe, I don't know, I can quit the Emerald Circle and help him manage it. Selling tickets and running concession stands isn't really what I envisioned for myself growing up, but... is a life on the road tending to the groves and wild places of the world?"

"Does it make you happy?"

"I think it will," Thaisha says. "But I don't know if it will make life meaningful."

"Saleander can't help you with that, either," Hazel says. "But, it's alright. It's bad luck to talk about the future, right before a big fight."

"Okay," Thaisha laughs. "I'll think about it."

Hazel casts *Enhance Ability* on herself as she gets up to bless the druid.

"Did you just - Did you just cast *Enhance Ability* on yourself?"

Hazel laughs. "Yes, I have to bless you."

"Oh, okay," Thaisha bows her head and shuts her eyes, awaiting Hazel's blessing.

"Are you sure you really don't want to explore doing something casual and low-commitment?"

With her eyes still shut and head bowed, Thaisha says, "Uh, I don't think that's what Saleander wants. I think she wants us to embrace life fully and deliciously - "

Casting *Thaumaturgy*, Hazel deepens her voice and says "Are you sure?"

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Hazel convinces Thaisha that she is wrong about Saleander's scripture.

"Uh, actually, no," the druid says. "It's been a while since I've read scripture."

"No worries my child," Hazel continues with her deep voice. "I'll always be here for you." The pair stay in prayer as Hazel continues preaching to the druid.

We cut over to Salazar's room, where we find Ariadne and Salazar. Both of you finish sharing your spellbooks and arcane research with one another. Salazar, you learn 15 Divination and Conjuration spells.

"High Mage Black," Ariadne begins. "I... have a confession to make."

"Pray tell," Salazar says. "What may that be?"

"Back at the Port," She says sheepishly. "I did something bad. I'm not sure if you heard about it, but I was there when Kaelen attacked Sir Wang Lei and Lord Antarra. I dare not speak to both of them. It is well within their rights to hold a grudge against me."

"Did they see you?"

"I think so," the elf replies anxiously. "You've been travelling with them for quite awhile. Is there anything you think I should do to help mend the bridges?"

"Well, they probably wouldn't remember you," Salazar says cautiously. "But, now that we are a team, we should of course be honest with one another," The wizard pauses, thinking. "Correct me if I'm wrong, but you didn't... *do* anything, right?"

"No, no," Ariadne explains. "Kaelen knew that I was a divination wizard, and that I was able to see and manipulate the strands of fate. He wanted me to make sure that the spell succeeds."

"Ah," Salazar says. "You were an insurance policy. And if push came to shove, would you have had carried out the task?"

"Yes," Ariadne admits. "They hired me. I didn't know that they wanted to attack all of you in that way, or that you were all with Vilde." The anxious wizard clasps Salazar's hands. "Please, could you keep this a secret between us? I would have asked Vilde, but I don't know. I don't want her to feel like she has to choose between me and them."

Wisdom (Insight) Check

On a successful **DC 14** check, Salazar can see that it is because Ariadne thinks that Vilde would pick them over her.

"Okay, don't worry, I will," Salazar says. "I think we can just talk to the two of them privately, and let them know that you were sorry. I'm sure they will understand." Sensing her insecurity, Salazar says, "In fact, let's do this. I'll go with you."

Ariadne nods. The pair walks out, finding Wang Lei and Mason returning from training.

"Eh, Wang Lei, our new team member has something to share," Salazar begins. He jerks his head at the pair, prompting Ariadne to speak.

The elf looks at her feet, and says, "Sir Wang Lei, I'm not sure if you remember this, but I was there with Kaelen when he attacked you at the Dinosaur Race. I'm sorry."

"Sorry for what?" Wang Lei asks, puzzled.

"For helping him do that?"

"No, don't say that," Salazar interjects. "I think what she meant to say was that she was under immense pressure, and I don't think she meant it." Salazar pauses, scrutinizing Wang Lei's expression. "I don't think she has any ill-intentions now that she's with us, and the fact that she is anxious about this shows that she wants to help us."

Wang Lei nods. "Of course, Ariadne. No worries." The knight and his squire heads off to keep their equipment as the pair of wizards make their way to Raphael's room.

"Full disclosure," Salazar admits. "I'm not on good terms with Raphael."

"Oh, okay," Ariadne says. "Why?"

"Sorcerers and wizards have always had a bit of a rivalry," He explains. "But that doesn't mean that I won't be there to support you."

Ariadne bites her lip, thinking. Salazar sees her unease as the elf comes to the realization that she may have confided in the wrong person.

Entering Raphael's room, you both see the sorcerer levitating above his bed with his eyes shut, reading the *Nekronomicon.*

"Um, Raphael," Salazar introduces, knocking on the door frame. "Our new team member is here to say hi."

The sorcerer continues his reading, ignoring the pair.

"Lord Antarra," the elf calls out. Raphael shuts the book and sits back down on his bed, opening his eyes in response.

"I'm sorry for helping Kaelen attack you at the race and steal your watch from you," Ariadne continues. Tears of fear well up in her doe eyes. "I was there to make sure his spell succeeds."

Salazar speaks up to help. "I think she was under a lot of pressure, and that she didn't mean it."

"They hired me," Ariadne nods. "I am a divination wizard, and I can see glimpses of the future, threads of fate and where they invariably lead. He wanted me there to make sure you'd fail to resist his spell."

"And," Salazar continues. "Now that her hands are untied, she might allow us to gain an edge over the 51st and help us destroy the Devourer. What do you say we let all this be water under the bridge?"

The sorcerer furrows his eyebrows, annoyed. "Why are you speaking up for her? Who are you to do that?"

"She confided in me," Salazar says. "And she was quite scared at our reaction - "

"Does Vilde know?"

"When I spoke to her, it didn't look like she knew," Ariadne confesses.

Raphael nods. "Well, I'm willing to let it all slide, on one condition. The next time you do it with us, to Kaelen."

Ariadne nods eagerly, smiling. With a massive weight lifted off her shoulders, the elven wizard can finally relax after being set free from her shackles almost five days ago.

Salazar winks with a brightest smile and a thumbs up, which Raphael notices.

"A word of caution," the sorcerer advises. "I think it's better if you stay away from the guy next to you. It's better if you stick with your sister."

Ariadne nods, thanking the sorcerer. She gives Salazar a quick thumbs up before heading out of the room without him.

Vilde. Done with cooking, you call the Party to come down for dinner. As you start packing up to head out to clean your chef's tools in the river, you hear the sound of wind kicking up wildly from outside the tent.

Before you can react, you hear two massive boots slam into the ground outside. What do you do?

“Uh, guys, guys!” Vilde calls out. “I think there’s someone here! Someone large!”

As the Party surge into action, you see Vorn and Claptrap pop in through the flaps. Vorn has two extra arms jutting out from his ribcage. Although Claptrap still has two arms, you see that his original two arms have been upgraded and can split into two to form four.

They rejoin the Party. As they do, Claptrap wheels up to you, Vilde and taps you. His chest torso opens up as he produces a small note.

Vilde pats the warforged medic, saying “Thank you.”

“Had to improvise on the little guy, no space for two more arms,” the note, signed by Theodore, writes. “Made headway on stabilizing planar travel. I think I’m ready to build the prototype. Let me know where.”

The Party, ecstatic at the return of their allies, eagerly begins dinner. Vilde shares the note to everyone.

“I thought we’d be in for a fight,” Salazar says.

“Did you want to?” Vilde asks.

Ariadne taps the rogue. “I, uh, spent an evening with High Mage Black, studying the arcane arts.” She eyes the room as her voice drops to a whisper, “I think I know what you were talking about.”

Replying in a whisper, Vilde says, “Yes, please. Next time just find Raphael.”

Gathering for dinner, you all feel a sense of palpable tension in the air. Anticipation gnaws at each of you as you realize that you are now, closer than ever, to your destination.

Raphael and Hazel. As you think about what you might face on the morrow in Raya, thoughts of inner strength, patience, compassion, and courage bubble to the surface of your mind.

Hazel asks, breaking the silence of the group. “Have you all ever felt scared or frightened?”

“Yes,” Ariadne nods eagerly.

“After all of our fights, I felt indestructible,” Hazel shares. “But after what happened at Camp Vengeance... I feel very, very mortal. I could have done it. I could have saved her. I felt her slip through my fingers. How do all of you get the strength to rush into battle? You see, I don’t do that.” Hazel summons her illusory duplicate as she continues to talk. “I summon my little helper to help fight for me.”



"Well," Vilde says. "If I had rushed into battle, she would have been saved."

Hazel nods, rubbing the rogue's back gently to comfort her. Mason leans forward and says, "I find my strength in the people that I love. I have to protect them, no one else will."

"Thanks Mason," Hazel continues. "I do think about why I'm here, what I'm here to do. I know I may have been chosen by chance, but I have a role to play in this Expedition."

Thaisha takes her focus off her food, staring quietly at Hazel as she continues talking.

"I do believe that we are bigger than our body," Hazel says. "Everytime I get scared when somebody brandishes a scimitar, or a crossbow, I do think about what's worse: to not fight, or to have fought, and failed?"

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

On a successful **DC 20** check, Hazel convinces Thaisha that she should not just flop over backwards and cater to the will of her husband, but that she should fight for the things she loves. Thaisha commits to her worship in Saleander again.

Wisdom (Insight) Check

Hazel recalls that Ariadne's tutelage at the Temple of Savras back in Port M'Kaze is likely due to her need for a scholarship to afford studying magic. On a successful **DC 20** check, Hazel can see that Ariadne is doing her research before deciding which goddess to declare for.

Hazel casts *Thaumaturgy,* using it to turn the green flame. As the Party settles into a contemplative mood, Raphael debates internally whether to share his secrets or not.

"Guys," Raphael finally says, just as the Party is about to finish their dinner. "I think that there are many questions on the things that I have been doing, ever since the battle at the Wreck of the Star Goddess. This entity is incredibly dangerous, and it has made me want to tread lightly. I want to harness as much power as I can from it, but I'm not sure if surrendering myself would be great for everyone. That applies to not just people in the Party, but also for the safety of my family back home."

The sorcerer pauses, sneaking a look at Thaisha to gauge her reaction. The druid's focus is firmly in the burning green campfire; Raphael can see that although she is listening, the half-orc has other matters on her mind.

"I seek everyone's understanding, to give me some space to figure it all out," Raphael continues. "The entity is something I may need to overcome eventually, but I want to assure everyone that the threat is not immediate. From my research with the *Nekronimicon*, if anything were to happen, it would probably be a year or so from now."

The sorcerer pauses again, this time surveying the entire Party. "We're a team," He declares. "I can't say for certain if there's anything else out there that might threaten us, but I hope that we, as companions to each other, can help one another." The sorcerer stands, walking to the middle of the campfire. He sticks his hand in, "We will reach Raya tomorrow. Let's fuck them up, together."

Mason stands, joining the circle. Wukong and Ariadne follow suit, as the rest of the Party joins in. Watching Hazel put her grubby paws in, Thaisha acquiesces. Gathered with their hands in the circle, the Party bonds.

"What are we going to shout?" Ariadne asks. "What do you all call yourselves, as an adventuring party?"

"I guess, five-two on the count of three?" Raphael suggests.

"That's a mouthful," Ariadne says.

"You are a mouthful," Hazel retorts.

"Don't scold the young lady," Salazar chides.

"Well," the sorcerer smiles. "What does everyone else think?"

"After we split off from Kaelen, we called ourselves Bells Hells," Ariadne says.

"Why Bells Hells?" Salazar asks eagerly.

"A placeholder then," Wang Lei suggests, ignoring the wizard.

"What about Dap Up?" Vilde offers. Mason and Ariadne exclaim their support, to the protests of the rest of the Party.

Salazar interjects, "What about the 'best of five'?"

Vilde rolls her eyes. "Do you think that's better?"

"Okay, okay," Raphael calls out, cutting over the cross-talk. With the entire Party's hands still in the circle, he says, "We can shout five-two for now, and then a competition about who can come up with the best name."

"Okay, how about - " Salazar begins, but nobody hears what he says. The Party cheers as they all shout uproariously: "Five-Two!"

Inspired by the group cheer, the Party resumes to their hearty dinner. Drinks clink around as conversations start up again, this time a lot more hopeful for their trip to Raya tomorrow.

Unkillable

Setting Vorn to take over his duties, Wang Lei takes his rest early. Eager to enjoy a full night's rest without having to wake up for duty, the warlock happily heads to rest. Unfortunately, his patron has other plans.

> You find yourself in a ruined city. Above you, the sky is dark red, as if bleeding by itself. You stand up, but find manacles all around you. In front of you is a raised stage. Hanging from a sturdy wooden beam, their heads around nooses, are the bodies of Castellan Raimond, Hazel, Raphael, Wukong, Thaisha, Mason, Sister Clara, Ariadne, and Vilde.

"Have you figured it out yet?" The Child appears, clutching his Teddy Bear. Taking into his appearance, Wang Lei sees that the Child is almost reaching full adulthood. Although he still has gray, pallor skin and jet black eyes, his features bear striking resemblance to the paladin's, as if the Child is intentionally adopting his appearance.

"Figured what out?"

"Who the real enemy is, of course," The Child says.

"The Hags, right?" Wang Lei offers. "I've found their weaknesses - "

"Oh, there's so much you don't know," The Child says. "Let me explain it to you, silly boy. After you destroyed the False Hydra, one of you looted Dead-Eye Demodus and found the 22nd Expedition's research, learning that Acererak has multiple, living phylacteries. Back at the prison, Gwynne told one of you that Acererak's phylacteries were not static objects, but a living thing. And yet, this individual has sought to keep everything quiet. Do you know why?"

"No."

"Because he's the phylactery! That's the reason why the Hags are so interested in all of you instead of the thousands of other adventurers trying to destroy the Devourer. It is because they found out that one of his phylacteries - Salazar - is a simulacrum who has somehow gained free will. Do you know what we have to do now?"

Wang Lei stays quiet, thinking. "Is there no other alternative?"

"There is," The Gray Child replies. "Acererak is reckless. Having split his soul into that many fragments, even destroying one would cause him to take years to reform. And of course, the more of his phylacteries we destroy, the longer he will take." He produces a small chain necklace. It has a tribal mask as its jewel, with emeralds etched into the mask's eyes.



"Slip this into the wizard's belongings. It will take a few days to work, but it is the only way we can stop Acererak. And, this is of paramount importance: do not let the wizard know the true purpose of this necklace. If he does, who knows what Acererak might do, through him."

Wang Lei takes the necklace, keeping it. "Do you know where his other phylacteries are?"

"No, I don't," the Child replies. "It is by sheer luck that we chanced upon Salazar at all."

"Okay," Wang Lei nods. "Anything else I need to know?"

"He will be waiting in the Tomb of Annihilation," The Child warns. "He will be there when we ascend."

"We?" The warlock asks.

"We are close now, my brother," The Child replies, nodding. "We have but a week left." His infinite, black eyes bores into Wang Lei. "I can sense it in you, you know. You don't have to hide it from me. I can sense your desire to break free from my control. But I'm afraid killing me is not an option. Not if you want to keep the powers that I have so happily provided. And besides, see it this way: when I ascend to my rightful place as a death god, you only need to kneel to me. You would rule by my side, over all life on this planet. Think about it! Vast millions at your feet, and but one to whom you would be answerable."

"Let's focus on the important thing now," Wang Lei urges. "We have to destroy the Devourer and Acererak."

"Destroy the Devourer?" The Child asks. "Why would you do that? I need the Devourer to become a god."

"Right, yeah," Wang Lei replies. "I misspoke."

The Child cocks his head, eyeing the paladin. "Now, run along, brother. And do not let the wizard know."

> The vision fades, and you find yourself in your bed.



Raya's Fall

Salazar. In your dream you stand on clifftops beside a roaring waterfall. You look down and see a city of magnificent, whitewashed buildings stretching out before you. Sunlight sparkles off of glass domes and windows. You see the streets are filled with throngs of people cheering and jeering as the city seemed to be jostling and streaming into a wide marble plaza.

This place is *packed.* It is crowded like a concert. The mob are equal parts men and women. You see some of the people here have children on their shoulders, clapping and shouting. Beggars and thieves, taverners and tradesfolk, tanners and stableboys and mummers.

At the center of the sea of hungry eyes and gaping mouths and dirty faces, the wizard sees that there is a small path through them. Guards force the crowd back as you see a line of shaved, naked prisoners, manacled together with muzzles around their mouths are paraded through the streets. These prisoners look to be a mix of men, women and even tabaxi as well. They have intricate, maze-like tattoos along their body.

Behind the last prisoner, ringing a bell, you hear a human man chiming the words even through the roaring din. "Shame! Shame! Shame!"

As they pass, people in the mob hurl rotten vegetables and eggs at the procession, striking the naked prisoners.

Wisdom (Religion) Check

On a **DC 15** check, Salazar can recognize the maze-like tribal tattoos on the naked prisoners marking them as Ubtao's priests.

You see that these prisoners are led away from the crowd, to a shrine.

Quicker than thought, just as your attention shifts towards the shrine, you are transported to their side. At the entrance of the shrine, you see there are two stone obelisks decorated with carvings of what looks like monkeys hanging by their tails. Behind the obelisks, is a small courtyard, housing a low gray building. Five archways open into darkness. Mounted above the central arch is a stone plaque bearing a complex inscription in a tongue you do not recognize. Written in Celestial is the phrase "Better to be Wongo's friend than his enemy."

Wisdom (Nature) Check

On a **DC 15** check, Salazar recognizes the monkeys as summonsters from his research earlier.

Arriving here, the guard unmanacle their prisoners. The man ringing the bell, you can see now is dressed in a black cloak. Draped around is neck is a green and gold cleric orphrey. At its ends are the symbol of an eye in a knot of wood.

You recognise that the man with the bell is dressed in Saleander's vestments.

"For heresy, and the worship of false idols," the human man says. "You are sentenced to death. And yet, for your confession, Saleander is pleased. She has considered the possibility of mercy and forgiveness. Repent for your sins. Survive the shrine, and you will gain absolution."

All of the people here look at the five archways, terrified. One of the women eyes the guards, as if weighing if she can outrun them. Seeing that they all have their blades at the ready, this woman turns and faces the shrine.

"We do not have all day," the human man says. "We start slitting throats in three, two - "

The six of them sprint. They race into the archways. You see two of them go in through the center while two others go to the ones by the left and the right.

As those on the side cross the threshold of the archway, you watch 600-pound portcullises slam shut. The gate crushes the naked prisoners, killing them instantly.

Salazar steps forward, trying to follow into the central archway. As he does so, he hears a cold, dead voice ring out from behind him, "You know, they were the best at that." Turning, Salazar sees a figure in tattered robes with a skull-tipped staff. His sunken eyes, deep within his dessicated flesh, contain nothing but two points of dead light.

The lich's skeletal fingers closes around your throat. You feel warmth and life drain from your body directly into the hand that chokes you now.

"Hello, my son," Acererak snarls. "Can I call you that? I mean, it's either that or twin, since you know, I fucking cloned you."





Resisting Divine Intervention

Salazar will need to beat a DC **23** Constitution saving throw to resist the effects. Fortunately for the wizard, he has Help.

Your voice croaks as your body is paralyzed by his touch. His eyes, twin balefires of sheer malice burn into you. You can tell that he's trying to regain his control of you.

You summon every ounce of arcana in your body, using it to shield your physical body. As it does so, you feel your mind become feeble, weakened. From now on, you gain Disadvantage on all Intelligence, Wisdom and Charisma saving throws.

As life drains out of you, your vision begins to fade to black. As you do so, you start to smell something wet and earthy. The smell of mud and mushrooms fill your nostrils and your lungs, so much so that it feels like you have stuck your nose into the dirt of the earth and took a deep breath. Golden light bursts forth from you as Acererak is knocked back with a scream.

You jolt awake. As your bedroom swims into view, you see colorful swirls of iridescent rabbits and mushrooms dissipating against the dark of your eyes.

Salazar comes to in his bedroom. He feels weak, but finds that he can move. Pins and needles stab numbly in his extremities. Rubbing his limbs, he feels sensation return to them once more.

Realizing that it is time for his watch duty, the wizard prepares half-heartedly. Distracted by the nightmare, Salazar heads down and finds Vilde.

"M'lady," the wizard begins, finding the rogue. "I had a really weird dream."

Afraid that she might be on the receiving end of another weird sex dream story, Vilde raises a quizzical eyebrow. "Okay... pray tell."

"I dreamt of Acererak, yet again," Salazar replies. "Do you know what a lich is?"

Vilde nods slowly.

"He's the Second Lich," Salazar explains. "The second most powerful undead spellcaster in the world. He and his master, they figured out how to make liches. I'm afraid this is bigger than us." The wizard sits quietly, struggling to find the right words. "He called me 'my son', cause he cloned me." Salazar's hands begin to tremble uncontrollably, as his breath quickens. "I think... I am the cause of all this. The world on the brink, the Graying, the Devourer, all of it." The wizard breaks down, crying. "I'm scared."

Vilde puts a comforting hand on his shoulder. "Yeah, I think that's probably true," the rogue says gently. "But do you even remember anything about your past?"

"No," the wizard cries. He struggles to catch his breath as he is racked with sobs.

"Then, I think you got to find out," Vilde replies simply. "Learn the truth together, with us."

"And if I do?" The wizard meets the eyes of the rogue, pleading. "Do you think I deserve to die, then?"

"It depends," Vilde says. "If given a choice, would you save the world, or save yourself?"

"The world," Salazar says, wiping tears away from his eyes. "And if that means I have to be give up on myself, then so be it. I'll do it."

Salazar. As the words leave your lips, the reality of what you have to be willing to give up in Raya hits you all at once. As you start bawling, in this moment of utter vulnerability and resolve, you level up.

The pair finishes their watch duty and return to rest. As the Party awakens the next day for breakfast, Wang Lei approaches Raphael.

"I need to speak to you in private," Wang Lei says, pulling Raphael aside.

Dexterity (Stealth) Check

Failing to beat Salazar's passive perception of 15, Raphael and Wang Lei are noticed by the wizard.

Salazar follows along, sitting just within earshot by the campfire with his back to the pair.

"Can you take a look at this?" Producing the necklace from the Child, Wang Lei hands it over for the sorcerer to inspect.

Intelligence (Arcana) Check

On a successful **DC 20** check, Raphael can see that it is a *Talisman of the Sphere*, which is an enchanted piece of jewelry that makes it easier for a spellcaster to control a *Sphere of Annihilation*. While holding or wearing this talisman, the spellcaster would have Advantage on any Intelligence (Arcana) check you make to control a Sphere of Annihilation.

Sphere of Annihilation

Wondrous Item, Legendary (requires attunement)

This 2-foot-diameter black sphere is a hole in the multiverse, hovering in space and stabilized by a magical field surrounding it.

The sphere obliterates all matter it passes through and all matter that passes through it. Artifacts are the exception. Unless an Artifact is susceptible to damage from a Sphere of Annihilation, it passes through the sphere unscathed. Anything else that touches the sphere but isn't wholly engulfed and obliterated by it takes 8d10 Force damage.

Controlling the Sphere. A Sphere of Annihilation is stationary until someone takes control of it. If you are within 60 feet of a sphere, you can take a Magic action to make a DC 25 Intelligence (Arcana) check. On a successful check, you control the sphere until the start of your next turn, and if it was under another creature's control, that creature loses control of the sphere. On a failed check, the sphere moves 10 feet toward you in a straight line. While in control of the sphere, you can take a Bonus Action to cause it to move in one direction of your choice, up to a number of feet equal to 5 times your Intelligence modifier (minimum 5 feet). Any creature whose space the sphere enters must succeed on a DC 19 Dexterity saving throw or be touched by it, taking 8d10 Force damage. A creature reduced to 0 Hit Points by this damage is obliterated, leaving its possessions behind but no other physical remains.

Raphael explains the *Talisman,* prompting suspicion from Wang Lei. Concerned that the potent magical item is not at all what the Child had advertised, Wang Lei asks "Do you know that if it may have any other effects?"



The sorcerer shakes his head, handing the *Talisman* back. "If you don't mind me asking, how did you come into possession of such an item?"

"Give me a minute," The warlock analyses the situation, realizing that the Child must be listening to him somehow if he is aware that Ariadne had recently joined the group. Wary that the Child is listening through the *Teddy Bear,* the warlock passes Vorn the powerful item before resuming the conversation with Raphael.

"My patron gave it to me," Wang Lei explains, his voice low. "But I suspect that he is up to something." Wang Lei shares his dream the previous night, and his conjecture that the patron may be acting against them to aid Acererak instead.

"At any rate," Raphael replies, thinking. "It sounds like your patron is giving Salazar this item, through you. And the item may empower Salazar, for good or ill of the Party."

The pair continue sharing their theories, before eventually deciding that Raphael will hold the item for safekeeping. The sorcerer commits to consulting the *Nekronomicon* to learn more about the *Talisman.*

Wisdom (Insight) Check

On a successful contested check, Raphael can feel a difference in the energy radiating from the paladin. Where previously it was Celestial in nature, it had recently shifted Fiendish. Now, once again, it is Celestial again.

The sorcerer intuits that the paladin has changed his oath.

"Since we're being honest with each other," Raphael says, looking around quickly before continuing. "The energy powering your magic... it feels different," He says slowly, mincing his words. "Some part of me cannot help but feel... wary."

"It is nothing you have to worry about now," Wang Lei replies matter-of-factly. "I am on the lookout for extraplanar beings entering this realm. Nothing to be worried about if you aren't planning on anything funny, like introducing an extraplanar being. I'm here to help."

"Lowkey, it's good," Raphael replies. "I need someone to watch out for me and pull me back, especially when I feel like I'm not in control."

"Okay, guys, check what I made," Vilde drops a delicious, vibrant dish of eggs poached in a sauce of tomatoes, olive oil, peppers, onion, and garlic, spiced with cumin, paprika, and cayenne pepper, gathering the group for breakfast.

"Uh, what's this?" Salazar says.

"I call it shakshuka," Vilde beams, proud. "I just threw it together."

Salazar looks around, confused. The rest of the Party dives in, eagerly devouring the savoury meal.

"Eh, you want eat or don't want eat?"

Begrudgingly, the wizard joins in.

The Lost City

After a long breakfast, the Party heads into Raya.

The jungle parts to reveal a dead city enclosed by sheer cliffs. Ruined buildings and stone boulevards rise like ghosts from the floor of the misty basin. Colorful birds glide overhead.

A waterfall pours into the basin, creating a swollen river that floods much of the city before draining into a deep rift filled with molten lava. Vilde, you recognize this place from your vision almost three weeks ago. You see the black, pulsing obelisk draped with vines in the north of the city, and a massive, ruined royal palace in the east, a few hundred feet from the edge of the steaming abyss.

From their vantage point, Vilde points out the obelisk that she saw in her vision. Raphael intuits that the obelisk is probably the Tomb of Annihilation, which houses the Devourer.

Salazar shares that "they need all nine puzzle cubes to open the Tomb," and that he saw one of the shrines before. The wizard points out the location of Wongo's shrine, which he had visited just last night.

"How'd you see it?" Ariadne asks.

"It came to me in a dream," Salazar replies.

"And it can be trusted? If it might be useful, you should share it with all of us."

Salazar shoots a look at Vilde, before coming clean. "If you guys remember, I had a previous dream with Acererak, which I described as a sex dream - "

"What?" The elf grabs her half-sister's hand, shocked.

"Now you know what I mean," Vilde replies.

"Turns out it is something more nefarious... I had another dream again, last night," Salazar continues. "He said something about me being his son, or his twin, cause he cloned me."

"Okay, I'm sorry," Ariadne says, perplexed. "What is this sex dream you're talking about?"

"Okay, we have to focus," Hazel interjects. "We're on a mission."

"Yeah, I don't think you'd want to know," Vilde says. "Wait till you hear about the time he shat his pants - "

"Wait, he did?!" Raphael asks.

"No, I didn't!" Salazar protests. "Okay, but the moral of the story is that Acererak came to me twice. Once, for what I thought was a goofy reason, but it turned out to be something more nefarious. Yesterday, in the dream, I was there, at the shrine - Wongo's shrine. That's where he grabbed me and spoke to me."

"Does that mean he is there?" Raphael asks. "Or maybe, he can detect if people can enter the shrine."

"Then how do we know this isn't a trap?" Vilde asks.

"We could avoid it," Mason points out. "Just avoid Wongo's Shrine?"

As Vilde, Raphael and Salazar debate on what to do, Mason nudges his knight. "Sir, do you think we should fly? Scout the city?"

"Yeah, good idea," Wang Lei says.

"We should comb the city as well," Raphael says. "We have not seen any living person since we left Vengeance. It may be dangerous."

Hazel surveys the area: without flight, the cleric sees that the only other way down is the waterfall, which plunges several hundred feet down.

The Party decides to split up. Wang Lei, Mason, Vilde and Thaisha take to the skies, with the druid carrying Hazel. They will do a quick survey of the city as the rest of the Party drops down, taking the waterfall. The Expedition will then reconvene on the near bank, consolidating before making their moves into the city.

Realizing that Duo and Princess will not be able to make the journey, Hazel hops up to the owlbear. "Stay safe, big guy," the rabbitfolk sends the beast into the jungle, directing him to keep out of sight and stay on the ridgeline. "And take care of the dinosaur."

The lumbering owlbear bends low, nudging his beak softly into the cleric.

Vilde clacks at Princess as well, wishing them both to stay safe. Princess screeches in response, as the pair head off into the jungle.

Thaisha wildshapes to a falcon, picking up the harregon. Wang Lei, you and Mason grab the side of your cloaks and dive off the waterfall, as the feathers ruffle and pull you up into the sky.

Vilde, you squeeze the hilts of the scimitars. Golden, glowing wings explode from your back. With a powerful whoosh, you shoot into the sky.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a **DC 15** check, the Party sees the Red Wizards' walled compound and the amphitheater. They see about forty or fifty Red Wizards in the compound, and a massive tyrannosaurus rex sleeping in the amphitheater. They also find a small staircase leading into the city.

On a **DC 20** check, the Party uses Celestial inscriptions to find the shrines. They find four of them: (1) "Obo'laka teaches us to tread warily and stay in the light," (2) "Kubazan urges us to tread without fear and to give back as much as we take," (3) "Papazotl teaches us to bow before no one," and (4) "Shagambi teaches us to fight evil with honor."

Ariadne casts *Feather Fall* on Salazar, Wukong, Raphael, Claptrap and Vorn. Threads of golden light connects the five of them, before weaving together to form a large parachute. The five of them run to the edge of the waterfall, leaping off into the city.